



DAVID BUTOW For The Times

LOOKING TO LEAD LOS ANGELES

Incumbent Karen Bass, left, and Nithya Raman spar at their mayoral debate Wednesday. **CALIFORNIA, B3**

SWALWELL BRIEFLY HELD IN FEDERAL INQUIRY

Ex-lawmaker’s phone is seized and his home searched months after sex assault allegations.

By RICHARD WINTON, DAKOTA SMITH AND MICHAEL WILNER

A federal investigation into former Rep. Eric Swalwell appeared to gain steam after agents seized his electronic devices and raided his Washington home over the weekend, even briefly holding the former lawmaker at San Francisco International Airport, a person familiar with the inquiry told The Times.

Swalwell, a Democrat from Dublin, dropped out of the California governor’s race and resigned from Congress in April after allegations that he sexually assaulted a former staffer and acted inappropriately with other young women, which he denied at the time. Before he dropped out of the race, polls indicated that Swalwell was among the front-runners.

The source said Swalwell was held Saturday at SFO for search purposes and released the same day. Federal prosecutors are using civil rights law to pursue an inquiry into his conduct as a member of Congress. Authorities in New York and Los Angeles County are conducting separate investigations.

His home was searched [See Swalwell, A6]

Private-equity firms see value in pro teams

By THUC NHI NGUYEN

One of Los Angeles’ celebrated professional sports franchises was owned by one local family for more than 45 years. Catering to Hollywood royalty and leaning into its “Showtime” charm, the Lakers became synonymous with the star-studded city. Two quick transactions later, the team now belongs to a New York-based venture capital titan who made his billions in technology and software.

Joshua Kushner, founder of venture capital firm Thrive Capital, and former Disney Chief Executive Bob Iger agreed to buy a majority stake in the Lakers last week. The Buss family’s grip on the NBA’s glamour franchise loosened in 2025 when they relinquished their majority share to Mark Walter. His businesses are under federal investigation for undisclosed insurance loans and Walter flipped the team after just 14 months.

In 1979, Jerry Buss bought the Lakers, the Forum and the Los Angeles Kings for

\$67.5 million. Now the Lakers alone are worth \$12.5 billion.

“It used to be, ‘Hey, I’m in this for the love of the game,’ ” said Ross Williams, a private-equity attorney and partner at law firm Reed Smith. “Like I measure the success of my investment based on whether we win championships. ... And now it’s becoming apparent that these are really, really good financial investments.”

The booming business of sports has attracted a flood of private-equity investment, and even the most notable franchises require the influx of cash to keep up in the arms race.

As of May, more than 74 North American professional teams had some level of private-equity involvement, according to the CFA Institute, an organization providing finance education to investment professionals. Private-equity-backed consolidators have been responsible for 61% of all merg-

[See Investors, A12]

Lakers channel to get bench? Spectrum’s plan to exit SportsNet adds to drama of sale

By MEG JAMES

For more than a decade, Los Angeles’ premier sports teams — the Lakers and the Dodgers — have relied on big-ticket TV rights deals to boost their operations and player payrolls.

But major changes are looming.

The prospective new Lakers owners — investor Joshua Kushner and former Walt Disney Co. Chief Executive Bob Iger — will inherit an uncertain long-term television picture for the team when they assume control of the storied franchise.

Charter Communications’ Spectrum service broadcasts Lakers games on

its SportsNet cable channel. The Lakers are set this fall to enter the 15th year of their long-term, \$3-billion agreement with the cable company to bring regular season action to local viewers.

But Charter executives have discussed exiting that relationship, which guarantees the team about \$200 million a year in revenue, according to people familiar with the company’s plans who were not authorized to comment.

Charter months ago retained investment bankers to find a buyer for El Segundo-based Spectrum SportsNet, which the company runs in tandem with the Dodgers-owned channel, SportsNet LA.

Charter’s interest in jettisoning the channel as fewer consumers watch cable TV has sparked fears within the Lakers organization about the stability of the critical revenue stream, according to a person familiar with the situation who was not authorized to speak publicly.

The Lakers and Kushner’s investment firm, Thrive Capital, declined to comment.

Stamford, Conn.-based Charter on Thursday finalized its \$34.5-billion purchase of Cox Communications, making Spectrum the dominant internet and television provider in Southern California, with coverage from Santa Barbara to the [See Spectrum, A12]

Texas oil firm can keep pumping off Santa Barbara

Federal judge also strips California of regulatory oversight of the operation.

By GRACE TOOHEY

A federal judge has ruled that a Texas-based oil firm can continue to pump oil through pipelines along the Santa Barbara County coast under an emergency order from the Trump administration. He also transferred much of the regulatory authority over the oil operation to federal officials, stripping the state of its oversight.

It’s a blow for California officials and environmental activists who have fought the controversial oil project from Sable Offshore Corp. for months, citing concerns about pipeline safety — and comes as the Trump administration continues to push efforts that could undermine the state’s ability to protect its treasured coastline.

U.S. District Judge Stephen V. Wilson, however, also chastised and fined Sable, ordering the Houston-based company to pay the

state almost \$1.5 million for violating a federal consent decree that outlined specific regulations for restart, which Sable didn’t abide by.

The sweeping Wednesday ruling provides the most in-depth judicial review yet of the Trump administration’s intervention in the off-shore project, in particular a U.S. Department of Energy order that called on Sable to begin pumping crude and invoked the Defense Production Act in the interest of national security. Sable executives, who have continued to court the Trump administration, relied on that order to revive the decades-old oil operation, which had been dormant since a pipeline burst near Refugio State Beach in 2015, causing one of the state’s worst oil spills. Before that, Sable’s efforts to restart drilling had been stalled for months as the company continued to clash with California regulators.

“The [Defense Production Act] Order does, as a matter of law, preempt the enforcement of any state law that conflicts with Sable’s ability to operate the on-shore pipeline,” Wilson wrote in his 45-page ruling [See Sable, A6]



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

MARTIN RAMIREZ, who works at a body shop near the warehouse, says the fire has made him sick.

A high health toll after Lineage fire

Data from clinics in Boyle Heights detail symptoms suffered by hundreds of residents.

By SALVADOR HERNANDEZ

Hundreds of Boyle Heights residents suffered health problems after a fire at a cold storage facility burned stubbornly for days, including respiratory infections, eye disorders and persistent cough, according to a new study.

The St. John’s Community Health study found the symptoms were “directly related to toxic exposure and smoke inhalation” and raises more questions about the long-term effect of the fire on people who live in the community.

The report tallies symptoms and the diagnosis of 1,306 patients who were treated at mobile clinics during a roughly six-week period after the fire started June 17.

“The health impacts from the Lineage fire are serious and severe,” Jim Man-

gia, chief executive of St. John’s Community Health, said in an interview. “This is clearly widespread.”

The findings echo the experiences residents living near the warehouse have shared for months.

Data from government officials show the air near the Lineage refrigerated warehouse fire carried astronomically high levels of smoke and soot, surpassing some of the worst air pollution during the Los Angeles County fires in January 2025.

The number of people going to emergency rooms with throat pain and concerns about smoke inhalation increased during this period.

Lineage officials declined to comment on the health study.

The data released Tuesday by St. John’s Community Health come from three mobile clinics that were deployed into the community after the fire ignited, according to a statement from the group.

Of 1,306 patients, 35.9% met “fire-related exposure criteria,” meaning they showed symptoms such as an acute upper respiratory [See Illnesses, A6]

Facing the music after LA Jazz Fest fail

This weekend, Martin Ludlow thought he would finally be on Dockweiler Beach, waiting for fans to arrive at the LA Jazz Festival.

Ludlow, the founder of the festival and event promotion firm Bridge Street Inc., imagined that he would be perched on the stage at sunrise, waiting for John Legend and Janelle Monáe to play for 40,000 people. “In a matter of hours, this place is going to get filled up with thousands of people dancing and celebrating,” he said, recalling his hopes for the show.

Yet on a scorching Monday afternoon, Ludlow sat alone at a streetside coffee shop in Eagle Rock, trying to account for how what would have been the biggest jazz event in Los Angeles history fell apart.

Instead of reveling in ferocious solos and ocean breezes, the city’s music and

Founder reflects on cancellation amid scrutiny over funding

By August Brown



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

“**RIGHT** now, it’s a brutal fishbowl,” says Martin Ludlow, above, about reaction to the festival collapse.

civic communities watched the festival collapse in the wake of missed permit deadlines, blown budgets and angry artists left stranded without shows. Fans asked how such a prominent festival, with pop headliners and vocal support from City Hall, imploded on Aug. 7, the day its programming was due to begin.

A consultant familiar with LA Jazz Festival’s finances (who requested anonymity, citing ongoing work on similar events) and several performing artists said the fest had long-standing financial issues, which were increasingly evident in the weeks before the show. Acts questioned whether Ludlow, a former City Council member who pleaded guilty to misappropriating funds in 2006, was the right person to attempt such an enormous festival, and how he plans to [See Festival, A7]

California orders fuel-efficient tires

State is only one in U.S. to mandate the replacement accessories be low-resistance. **CLIMATE, A9**

Officials release Delta water plan

Environmental advocates say proposal would pose a further threat to fish. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather
Lots of sun; warm.
L.A. Basin: 91/70. **B6**

Markets **A11**
Opinion Voices **A13**

Startups attract high investments

Companies in California draw \$366 billion in venture capital, leading the U.S. **BUSINESS, A10**

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